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W E D N E S D A Y , M A Y 2 0 , 2 0 2 6

Despite new law, tenants still face broker fees

Some landlords continue to charge in tight market

By Andrew Brinker
GLOBE STAFF

On Wendell Street near Harvard Square — one of the most sought-after neighborhoods in the United States — an apartment was listed for rent this month that was sure to attract a swarm of interested renters.

It was a two-bedroom bathed in natural light, with a galley kitchen and plenty of counter space. And the rent? Just \$3,200 a month, utilities included. Not bad, given the neighborhood.

But buried near the bottom of the Craigslist listing was one inconvenient detail: a \$1,600 broker fee.

Such a fee can be jarring for prospective tenants in Boston's high-dollar housing market, especially after state lawmakers last year declared victory over the only-in-Massachusetts practice of charging substantial broker fees to rent an apartment. Last July, when Governor Maura Healey signed a law requiring the fee be paid by whoever first works with the broker — be it landlord or tenant — she called it an outright “ban” on the long-detested system.

But nearly a year later, it's apartment hunting season again, and broker fees haven't gone away.

The Globe identified dozens of listings on rental sites like Zillow, Apartments.com, and Craigslist — where many apartment rentals in the region change hands — that include a tenant-paid broker fee, often equivalent to one month of rent.

And tenants have reported being told to pay broker fees during their apartment searches, sometimes only learning of the fee upon tour-

BROKER FEES, Page A10

Cambridge stops using gunshot tech

Concerns about system's reliability, 'overpolicing'

By Spencer Buell
GLOBE STAFF

For many years, a network of microphones in Cambridge known as ShotSpotter has been listening for the sounds of gunshots, in an effort to quickly alert police and other first responders to a potential crime or injuries.

But this week, despite the pleas of their top police official, city councilors voted to turn them off, saying that they believe the tech isn't reliable, that it can lead to overpolicing, and that it might aid a federal government whose immigration agenda the city doesn't support.

Councilors on Monday night directed the city manager to end the use of ShotSpotter devices in Cambridge within 90 days. Even in the liberal and reform-minded city, it represents a turnaround, and a new sign that progressive leaders are coming to see government surveillance technology, in some cases, as doing more harm than good.

Five members of the nine-person council voted in favor, with two against and two others voting present.

“It poses a privacy and safety risk for residents,” said City Councilor Ayah Al-Zubi, a co-sponsor of the policy. “I believe the benefit does not outweigh the risks of situations where our Police Department might be misled.”

The vote follows years of debate over the usefulness, and potential harms of the technology, which is managed by a private company called SoundThinking and paid for in many cit-

SHOTS, Page A7

A next-level clash in quiet Sudbury

Residents will vote on no-confidence in School Committee

By James Vaznis
GLOBE STAFF

Special town meetings are held across Massachusetts to address a variety of urgent issues: a spiraling fiscal crisis, zoning changes to lure in a lucrative business development, or a time-sensitive land acquisition or school construction project.

Then there's Sudbury, known for its rural tranquility and million-dollar homes. Residents will gather Wednesday night for a special Town Meeting to take up

an unusual order of business for a town with among the best public schools in the state: a vote of no confidence in the School Committee.

Convening a special town meeting to vote no-confidence in a school committee is considered rare in Massachusetts and reflects a growing dissatisfaction among many Sudbury residents.

Over the past year, the School Committee has repeatedly sparked controversy as it pursued a variety of proposals, in-

cluding expanding support for LGBTQ+ students, potential changes to afterschool programs, and the apparent ouster of the district's longtime superintendent, who achieved one of the strongest pandemic recoveries in the state.

The flurry of proposals, pursued by a board with significant turnover, elicited toxic postings on social media sites and eventually galvanized a group of residents to gather the 200 signa-

SUDBURY, Page A10



PAT GREENHOUSE/GLOBE STAFF

The Sudbury School Committee has said little about Superintendent Brad Crozier's exit in June with three years on his contract.

RELIEF PICTURE

On a day of record-breaking heat in Boston for the date, Rings Fountain on the Rose Kennedy Greenway was the place to be for 7-year-old Ace Casilla (center). The temperature hit 96 in the city, with more on the way today. **B1.**



DAVID L. RYAN/GLOBE STAFF

It's my understanding that Boston 26 did not think it was incumbent upon it to come up with a deal that would work for all involved.

It's not too late for Boston to get Airbnb on board for Cup

SHIRLEY LEUNG
POWER PLAY

Here's another tale about the gang that can't shoot straight: Our vaunted World Cup host committee, Boston 26.

Last summer, officials from Airbnb met with Boston 26 about sponsoring World Cup festivities as soccer fans descend upon the region for seven games this summer. The short-term rental giant, which is an official FIFA partner, had set aside \$5 million to spend on World Cup programming at 16 host cities in North America.

On the same Zoom call, Airbnb brought up something it's hoping to see happen in host cities: Relaxing short-term-rental regulations during the Cup, to make it easier for people to rent out their homes, or what's known as a special event exemption.

The meeting put Boston 26 on edge

and it didn't pursue a deal with Airbnb, for reasons that fairly sum up why local World Cup organizers can't seem to get out of their own way.

According to a person knowledgeable about the call, the rationale went something like this: No way we're approaching Mayor Michelle Wu. She was in the midst of a reelection fight against Josh Kraft, son of Robert Kraft, the driving force behind bringing the World Cup to Boston. Asking her to do a favor to help the Cup? Awkward. Not only that, Wu, back when she was a city councilor, was the lead author of the short-term rental rules that Airbnb wanted to relax.

Then there was Meet Boston. The tourism agency is one of Boston 26's biggest funders, and is itself largely funded by taxes on Boston and Cambridge hotels. Those hotels see Airbnb as a major competitor, and while Meet

POWER PLAY, Page A7

Twist on history finds an audience in Trumpland

Traveling 'Freedom Trucks' paint a rosier Colonial picture

By Julian E.J. Sorapuru
GLOBE STAFF

BEL AIR, Md. — As I stood face to face with George Washington, he told me, “The fate of our country, the fate of liberty, is in your hands.” A few seconds later, he froze in to the iconic pose of the Lansdowne portrait: right hand outstretched, left hand gripping the sword at his hip. It was like a scene out of “Night at the Museum.”

The AI-generated video of Washington — whose full speech runs about 2 minutes and 30 seconds — is the opening attraction of six “Freedom Trucks” on tour throughout the nation. The mobile museums are hitched to semitrucks and contained within specially made trailers decorated with another famous painting of Washington, making the Delaware River crossing.

The project is part of Freedom250, a public-private partnership working in tandem with the White House's Task Force 250 to carry out President Trump's vision for the country's semiquincentennial.

Although the trucks themselves lack overt political messaging, the organization that curated the exhibit,

TRUCKS, Page A6



BOSTON HARBOR HOTEL

Beer gardens of delight

When the weather's nice, there's no better spot. Check out 11 beer gardens worth checking out around Boston right now (at left, Trillium Garden at Boston Harbor Hotel). **G1.**

The median cost of a home in the Boston area surged, reaching a new high of \$1 million. **B5.**

The US government will permanently drop tax claims against President Trump. **A2.**



Governor Maura Healey appointed new leaders to run the Cannabis Control Commission. **B5.**

Scientists say their worst and best case scenarios for a warming world are no longer plausible. **A4.**

Mayin' course

Wednesday: Hot, storms. High 91-96. Low 54-59.

Thursday: Much cooler. High 62-67. Low 46-51.

Sunrise: 5:18 Sunset: 8:04.

Weather and Comics, G6-7.

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